Chicago or Paris in 1968 could easily have given the impression that things were falling apart. The pressure to live up to the democratic ideals and to include more people and groups in the public conversation seemed to undermine the social order and to make democracy unworkable.

Meanwhile, the regimes behind the Iron Curtain, which never promised inclusivity, continued stifling the public conversation and centralising information and power. And it seemed to work. Though they did face some peripheral challenges, most notably the Hungarian revolt of 1956 and the Prague Spring of 1968, the communists dealt with these threats swiftly and decisively. In the Soviet heartland itself, everything was orderly.

Fast-forward twenty years, and it was the Soviet system that had become unworkable. The sclerotic gerontocrats on the podium in Red Square were a perfect emblem of a dysfunctional information network, lacking any meaningful self-correcting mechanisms. Decolonisation, globalisation, technological development and changing gender roles led to rapid economic, social and geopolitical changes. But the gerontocrats could not handle all the information streaming to Moscow, and since no subordinate was allowed much initiative, the entire system ossified and collapsed.

The failure was most obvious in the economic sphere. The overcentralised Soviet economy was slow to react to rapid technological developments and changing consumer wishes. Obeying commands from the top, the Soviet economy was churning out intercontinental missiles, fighter jets and prestige infrastructure projects. But it was not producing what most people actually wanted to buy – from efficient refrigerators to pop music – and lagged behind in cutting-edge military technology.

Nowhere were its shortcomings more glaring than in the semiconductor sector, in which technology developed at a particularly fast rate. In the West, semiconductors were developed through open competition between numerous private companies like Intel and Toshiba, whose main customers were other private companies like Apple and Sony. The latter used microchips to produce civilian goods such as the Macintosh personal computer and the Walkman. The Soviets could never catch up with American and Japanese microchip production, because – as the American economic historian Chris Miller explained – the Soviet semiconductor sector was ‘secretive, top-down, oriented toward military systems, fulfilling orders with little scope for creativity’. The Soviets tried to close the gap by stealing and copying Western technology – which only guaranteed that they